01 / CHOOSE YOUR TEST

Which IELTS?

Academic

Typically used for undergraduate or postgraduate study and some professional registration.

General Training

Typically used for some immigration routes and for work-related training or study below degree level.

BEFORE YOU BOOK

Ask your university, professional body, employer or immigration authority which test and delivery mode it accepts. Check the overall band and any minimum for each skill.

TEST TYPES

05 / RESULTS & NEXT STEPS

Band scores

0–9

You get a score for each skill. Your overall band is the average of the four scores, rounded to the nearest whole or half band.

EXAMPLE

7.0 + 6.0 + 6.0 + 6.0
Average 6.25 → overall band 6.5

Each organisation sets its own score requirements. IELTS recommends treating results as valid for two years. Check the policy for your application.

OFFICIAL IELTS RESOURCES

Academic test format

General Training test format

Band scoring explained

Sample test questions

IELTS.org

SCORES & PREPARATION

TEST TAKER'S GUIDE

IELTS

Academic & General Training

Compare the two English tests and see what to expect in each section.

L **Listening**

R **Reading**

W **Writing**

S **Speaking**

International English Language Testing System

ENGLISH LANGUAGE TESTS

02 / BOTH TESTS

Same format

Listening

ABOUT 30 MIN / 40 QUESTIONS

Listen to four recordings, played once each. They include conversations and talks in everyday and educational settings.

Speaking

11–14 MIN / 3 PARTS

Speak with an examiner in three parts.

1. Answer questions about familiar topics.
2. Prepare for one minute, then speak for up to two minutes on a topic.
3. Discuss broader questions related to that topic.

LISTENING & SPEAKING

03 / DIFFERENT TASKS

Academic

Reading

60 MIN / 40 QUESTIONS

Read three longer texts on topics of general interest, written for non-specialist readers. Texts can come from books, journals, magazines or newspapers.

Writing

60 MIN / 2 TASKS

TASK 1 / AT LEAST 150 WORDS

Summarise visual information such as a graph, table, chart, map or process diagram.

Example Compare changes in travel habits shown in a chart.

TASK 2 / AT LEAST 250 WORDS

Write an essay responding to an opinion, argument or problem. Task 2 counts twice as much as Task 1.

READING & WRITING

04 / DIFFERENT TASKS

General Training

Reading

60 MIN / 40 QUESTIONS

Read everyday material such as notices, workplace texts such as staff guidelines, and one longer text on a topic of general interest.

Writing

60 MIN / 2 TASKS

TASK 1 / AT LEAST 150 WORDS

Write a letter in response to an everyday situation. Use a personal, semi-formal or formal tone as appropriate.

Example Write to a venue manager to ask about hiring a room.

TASK 2 / AT LEAST 250 WORDS

Write an essay responding to an opinion, argument or problem. Task 2 counts twice as much as Task 1.

READING & WRITING